

Determining critical phase transition temperature in an Ising model simulation

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TODO: <Abstract>

I. INTRODUCTION

A. The Ising model

The Ising model named after the physicist Erns Ising is a model in statistical mechanics. The model consists of discrete magnetic spin dipole moments that take values ± 1 ("up" and "down" respectively) arranged on a lattice. For the purposes of our simulation we used a square lattice. The spins interact with only a subset of all the spins that are "close", we call this subset the neighbouring spins. It is known that this model exhibits phase transitions that can be associated with the gas-liquid transition or spontaneous magnetisation[1].

B. Aim of study

In this article we look at determining at what temperature does the Ising model undergo a phase transition. It is known from theory that under a certain critical temperature the model stabilises into completely up or down state. Conversely, above this critical, on average, the model remains a random mixture of up and down spins. We then try to experimentally try to determine the value of this critical temperature.

II. THEORY

In the Ising model, the lattice spin elements take the values $s_i = \pm 1$. The interaction energy between two spins is given by

$$E_{\text{int}} = -Js_i s_j, \quad (1)$$

where $J > 0$ is the coupling constant for ferromagnetic interactions and the s_i being the value of spin of spin i . We define the reduced interaction energy as $E_r = \frac{E_{\text{int}}}{J} = -s_i s_j$. The reduced interaction energy with the j nearest neighbours is then

$$E_r = \sum_{\langle j \rangle} s_i s_j, \quad (2)$$

The total amount of energy of the whole spin lattice is given by the sum over all pairwise interaction energies. This is then denoted as

$$E_{\text{sys}} = -J \sum_{\langle i, j \rangle} s_i s_j, \quad (3)$$

where the sum over i, j counts every pair only once with $(i, j) \equiv (j, i)$. The reduced system energy is then given by

$$E_{\text{sys-red}} = \frac{E_{\text{sys}}}{J} = - \sum_{\langle i, j \rangle} s_i s_j, \quad (4)$$

We then define another dimensionless quantity, the reduced temperature as

$$T_r = \frac{k_B T}{J}, \quad (5)$$

where T is the physical temperature, k_B is the Boltzmann's constant and J the coupling constant. We then only work in terms of this reduced temperature and give no physical values of T or J .

The theoretical value of the critical reduced temperature was predicted by Lars Onsager to be

$$T_c = \frac{1}{H_c} = \frac{1}{\frac{1}{2} \ln(\cot(\frac{\pi}{8}))} = \frac{2}{\ln(1 + \sqrt{2})}, \quad (6)$$

where $H = J_r$ is the reduced coupling constant and H_c is the critical coupling constant[2].

Later, in 1952, Yang Chen-Ning showed that the function of absolute value of average magnetisation as a function of reduced temperature is given by

$$|\langle m \rangle|(T_r) = \left[\frac{1 + x^2}{(1 - x^2)^2} (1 - 6x^2 + x^4)^{\frac{1}{2}} \right]^{\frac{1}{4}}, \quad (7)$$

with $x = e^{-\frac{2}{T_r}}$ [3].

The heat capacity of the Ising model is given by

$$C = k_B \beta^2 (\langle E^2 \rangle - \langle E \rangle^2), \quad (8)$$

where $\beta = \frac{1}{k_B T}$ [1]. We can modify to equation to get an expression for the heat capacity in terms of the reduced energy E_r and reduced temperature T_r as

$$\begin{aligned} C &= k_B \beta^2 (\langle E^2 \rangle - \langle E \rangle^2), \\ &= k_B \frac{1}{k_B^2 T^2} (\langle E^2 \rangle - \langle E \rangle^2), \\ &= k_B \frac{1}{J^2 T_r^2} (\langle E^2 \rangle - \langle E \rangle^2), \\ &= k_B \frac{1}{J^2 T_r^2} \mathcal{J}^2 (\langle E_r^2 \rangle - \langle E_r \rangle^2), \\ &= k_B \frac{(\langle E_r^2 \rangle - \langle E_r \rangle^2)}{T_r^2}. \end{aligned}$$

We define the dimensionless reduced heat capacity as

$$C_r = \frac{C}{k_B} = \frac{(\langle E_r^2 \rangle - \langle E_r \rangle^2)}{T_r^2}. \quad (9)$$

III. METHODOLOGY

A. Metropolis algorithm

To simulate the evolution of the Ising model we use a Monte Carlo simulation using the Metropolis algorithm. In our implementation we consider the von Neumann neighbourhood of only 4 neighbouring spins in the $\pm x$ and $\pm y$ directions. We also use a periodic boundary condition such that if we denote by $n \times n$ the size of the lattice, we have that the spin at position (n, i) is a neighbor of spin at position $(1, i)$ and in the same way also spin at i, n is neighbouring the spin at $(i, 1)$. At each iteration of the algorithm a random position is chosen in the square lattice of spins. The energy needed to flip the spin from the up to the down state or vice versa is then calculated from Eq. (2) as

$$\Delta E = E_{\text{before}} - E_{\text{after}} = \sum_{\langle j \rangle} (-s_i) s_j - \sum_{\langle j \rangle} s_i s_j = -2 \sum_{\langle j \rangle} s_i s_j. \quad (10)$$

We then have 2 cases. If $\Delta E \leq 0$, we flip the spin orientation. If $\Delta E \geq 0$, we accept the flip with probability $p = e^{-\frac{\Delta E}{T_r}}$. In order to do this, we sample a random variable $X \sim \text{Unif}(0, 1)$ and check $X < p$, in which case we accept the flip and leave the spin unflipped otherwise. We know that for values of the reduced temperature below the critical temperature i.e. $T_r < T_c$ the system gets to an equilibrium state where the absolute value of the average magnetisation goes to 1[1]. This however takes a certain amount of spin-flip attempts before the equilibrium is reached. To calculate the average quantities $|\langle m \rangle|$ and C_r we then wait for a certain amount of spin-flip attempts before gathering values then used to calculate these quantities to give the model enough time to reach equilibrium.

B. Determining parameters for final simulation

For the simulation that produced Figure 1 we had a number of requirements. The first requirements was for the simulation that produces the figure we use in this article to take no longer than 20 minutes to run. This meant that we had to look for simulation parameters that produce good data but for the simulation runtime to stay within the time bound.

We already knew from test simulations that the critical temperature was somewhere in the range $1 < T_c < 3$ as we ran simulation for $T_r = 1.5$ and $T_r = 3$ and observed the behaviour associated with reduced temperatures being lower and higher than the critical temperature respec-

tively. This then set the range of reduced temperatures that we were going to simulate.

We then continued to choosing a size of the lattice that we want to simulate as this, we found, had impact on the number of spin-flip attempts needed for the model to reach equilibrium. We decided to use $n = 50$ as for values of $n < 20$ we found that the equilibrium was disturbed to a great degree by the non-zero value of the temperature causing fluctuations in the spins.

We then ran multiple simulations trying to ascertain the number of spin-flip attempts needed for the 50×50 lattice to reach equilibrium for the temperature range we wanted to study. We found that the configuration that took the most amounts of spin-flip attempts to reach equilibrium was the one with the lowest temperature, namely $T_r = 1.5$. We decided on the number $k = 27'000'000$ for the amount of spin-flip attempts to wait before collecting values of the system energy and magnetisation for the average magnetisation and heat capacity calculations.

We then collect 500 of these quantities to average, one every 27'000 spin-flip attempts.

Finally, we tried to run as many individual simulations for every temperature value we were interested in, while also doing the simulations for a decent enough number of different temperature values to get a good resolution in our final results. We decided to do 42 simulations for each of 43 different temperature values.

IV. RESULTS

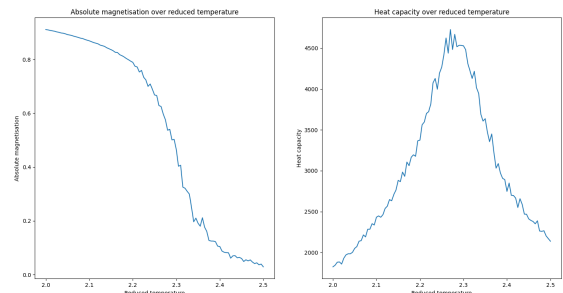


FIG. 1. Results

TODO: <Give results>
TODO: <Give figures of results>

V. COMPARISON TO THEORY

Using our simulation we obtained a value for the critical temperature as $T_r = \langle \text{TODO} \rangle$ using the fit over the values of average magnetisation and a value of $T_r = \langle \text{TODO} \rangle$ using the values of heat capacity. The theoretical value is given in Eq. (6). We can see

that... **TODO:** <Compare our results with theoretical values>

VI. CONCLUSIONS

Conclusion.

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- [2] Lars Onsager. Crystal statistics. i. a two-dimensional model with an order-disorder transition. *Physical Review*, 65(3-4):117–149, 1944.
- [3] C. N. Yang. The spontaneous magnetization of a two-dimensional ising model. *Physical Review*, 85(5):808–816, 1952.